Apex Systems

Response to RFP NW-2025-014: Vendor Onboarding Platform for Northwind Logistics

1. Executive Summary

Northwind Logistics needs a single platform to onboard, verify and monitor its 3,000 vendors across freight, warehousing and last-mile delivery. Apex Systems proposes a multi-tenant, API-first onboarding platform built on a microservices architecture, deployed in two cloud regions with automatic failover.

Our design prioritises security, auditability and integration depth. We will deliver a production-ready platform in 28 weeks, at a fixed price that reflects a premium engineering and security investment.

2. Proposed Solution and Technical Approach

The platform uses an event-driven architecture with a managed message broker, horizontally scalable stateless services and a PostgreSQL cluster with read replicas. Load tests on comparable deployments sustained 1,200 requests per second with a 95th percentile latency under 180 ms.

Integrations are delivered through a documented REST and webhook API plus certified connectors for SAP S/4HANA, Oracle Transportation Management and Microsoft Entra ID. Each connector ships with contract tests and a sandbox. Document intake uses configurable workflows with rule-based risk scoring and automated sanctions and tax-ID checks.

3. Timeline, Team Structure and Milestones

Delivery runs for 28 weeks in four phases: Discovery and design (weeks 1-5), Core build (weeks 6-16), Integration and security hardening (weeks 17-24), and Pilot and go-live (weeks 25-28). The team has 11 people: a delivery lead, a solution architect, six engineers, a security engineer, and a QA lead.

Milestones: M1 design sign-off (week 5), M2 core workflows demo (week 12), M3 integrations complete (week 22), M4 penetration test closed (week 25), M5 production go-live (week 28).

4. Pricing

Pricing is a fixed fee for a three-year term. The table below itemises each component.

Item	Price (USD)
Platform licence (3-year term)	540,000
Implementation services	420,000
Integrations (ERP, TMS, SSO)	210,000
Security hardening and penetration test	90,000
Training	40,000
Contingency reserve	120,000
Total	**1,420,000**

Pricing assumptions

- Prices are in USD, exclusive of taxes, fixed for the 3-year term.
- Northwind provides timely access to ERP and TMS sandbox environments.
- Up to three change requests per phase are included.

5. Security, Compliance and Risk Controls

Apex Systems holds SOC 2 Type II and ISO 27001 certifications, both audited in the last 12 months. Data is encrypted in transit with TLS 1.3 and at rest with AES-256, using customer-managed keys. Single sign-on supports SAML 2.0 and OIDC with enforced multi-factor authentication.

All administrative and data-access events are written to an immutable audit log retained for seven years. An independent penetration test is performed before go-live and annually. Personal data is processed under a GDPR-aligned data processing agreement with regional data residency options.

Key risks and mitigations: integration complexity with legacy ERP (mitigated by early connector spikes), and data-migration quality (mitigated by two dry-run migrations).

6. Support Model, Experience and References

Standard support covers business hours with a one-hour response for severity-1 incidents; 24x7 coverage is available as an option. A named technical account manager is assigned to Northwind.

Apex Systems has delivered nine onboarding or supplier-management platforms since 2019. References: Harborline Freight (supplier portal, 2023) and Meridian Foods (vendor compliance, 2022); contacts available on request.